A Regime Theory of Joy

This article presents the theoretical framework underlying the M-ZRT and includes a practical example of a session

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A Regime Theory of Joy is a theory I developed independently to explain the mechanisms underlying joy. I propose that joy is not merely a reward state, but an access regime. Its emergence depends on the temporary prevention of premature cognitive closure. When evaluative closure processes (Z) are sufficiently reduced, the state can continue developing until it reaches a threshold-like transition into autonomous deployment.

The second contribution of this work is the proposal of a task designed to induce joy.

Originality of the theoretical framework. To the best of our knowledge, this is the first theoretical framework to identify **action coupling** as the primary variable governing access to joy, and to derive from this principle a systematic set of behavioral perturbations designed to reduce it.

Before Beginning the Task

This task involves a transition toward a different brain regime, in which comparison, anticipation, and evaluation temporarily cease to dominate, allowing a mode in which optimization is suspended.

Consequently, simply approaching the protocol as a problem to solve already moves away from the regime it seeks to produce. Constructing a hierarchy has the same effect, because every hierarchy depends on comparison. Asking questions such as *"Which exercise should I do?"* or *"How often should I perform it?"* already recruits the very cognitive processes that the protocol is intended to suspend.

The protocol therefore begins by treating all available options as equally acceptable. Only from this position can the task begin.

Not performing an exercise is not considered a failure. It is simply one of the acceptable outcomes.

Before beginning, it may be helpful to say to yourself once: **"There is nothing to optimize here."** Treat this sentence as a single local action that requires no verification. Repeating it in the hope of making the protocol more effective would already reintroduce optimization into the task itself.

An attempt to optimize would therefore shift cognitive processing back toward the opposite regime.

With regard to mental activity, it is advisable to avoid imagined conversations. Beyond that, it is generally preferable not to interfere with the normal flow of thought. Simply avoid treating thoughts as instructions that must be acted upon immediately.

Protocol

Do not repeat the exercises excessively.

Several attempts spread over a few days may be required before a meaningful transition occurs. The principal cause of failure is doing too much. Perform only one attempt per day.

The aim is to produce a regime shift. It is therefore normal for the current regime not to welcome this attempt or cooperate spontaneously. For example, when you perform an exercise without immediately checking its outcome, the current regime may generate a strong urge to verify it or, more simply, encourage you to abandon the exercise altogether.

One way the current regime defends itself is by subtly reducing your interest in the exercise. Thoughts such as *"This isn't for me"* may arise. If the goal is to facilitate a regime shift, it is preferable to continue despite these signals, without trying to suppress or analyze them.

The current regime is generally willing to optimize rest, but not to suspend optimization itself. Yet this is precisely what the **M-ZRT (Minimal Z-Reduction Task)** proposes.

Simply acknowledge these reactions, then continue normally. If the protocol feels confusing, raises questions, or is even somewhat unpleasant, this is generally consistent with the hypothesis that the current regime does not "understand" why optimization itself is being suspended.

Paragraph Fragments

Read a single line, then move to an unrelated paragraph, or expose yourself to small fragments of text that have no obvious connection to one another. Do not deliberately search for an interpretation. If one arises spontaneously, simply move on to another paragraph, sometimes even before it has fully formed. There is no ideal moment to do so.

Each fragment remains an isolated element rather than becoming integrated into a coherent sequence of unfolding meaning.

The Core Task

- Perform a small movement without comparing it to a before or an after. Repeat this exercise 4-5 times.
- Perform a small movement while experiencing it as something that simply "happened," as though you were not its author. Movement → "It happened". Repeat this exercise 4-5 times.
- After looking at the time, briefly imagine that a different time appears instead. For example, **11:24 → 7:13** or **11:24 → 14:31**. Repeat this exercise 4-5 times.
- For a brief moment, treat a completely ordinary object as highly important. Repeat this exercise 4-5 times. Cup → Highly important.
- Launch a music video, then briefly look at an irrelevant background detail of the video. Music video → Wall texture. 1 time.
- Launch a music video. During the first ten seconds, do not evaluate the media or your reaction to it, and do not adjust the volume. Media begins → No evaluation. Volume → No adjustment 1 time.

These exercises briefly disrupt automatic action recruitment, temporarily lowering the level of **Z** and thereby increasing the probability of a transition toward another regime. By contrast, if an exercise is performed with analysis, anticipation, or verification of its effects, the brain automatically recruits a different set of action policies, increasing **Z** instead.

Optional Exercise for Walking Outdoors

The Other Side

For a brief moment, let both sides of the street seem equally acceptable. Then continue normally. Left side ≈ Right side. Repeat this exercise 4-5 times.

Rationale for the Task

In *A Regime Theory of Joy*, joy refers to a specific positive affective state characterized by a pleasant sensation radiating from the chest together with heightened olfactory sensitivity. This distinctive phenomenology helps, at least in part, to rule out an explanation based solely on a placebo effect or on the novelty of the task.

The increase in olfactory sensitivity may reflect greater engagement of the hippocampal system. If so, the hippocampus, through its role in contextual memory and associative processing, could enrich the variety and diversity of subjective experience, producing a broader range of positive experiential "textures."

In this state, colors may appear exceptionally vivid, almost as though they had a sweet taste. Odors can evoke the feeling of entering another world, and small shimmering objects may spontaneously elicit particularly rich mental imagery.

This may explain why certain moments, particularly during childhood, when access to this state is hypothesized to be easier, are often experienced and remembered as unique.

A common assumption is that the environment itself produces this feeling. The framework proposed here instead suggests that the environment primarily acts as an amplifier of a brain configuration that is already accessible.

In principle, this hypothesis implies that it could be theoretically possible to remain in such a positive state indefinitely.

Joy as a Problem of Causal Rigidity

According to **A Regime Theory of Joy**, the principal obstacle to the emergence of joy is neither a lack of reward nor a dopaminergic deficit, but the progressive rigidification of acquired causal chains. Through learning, the brain accumulates countless cause-and-effect relationships that organize perception and behavior. This cumulative rigidity is represented by the variable **Z**.

As **Z** increases, it progressively recruits a control regime specialized for prediction, optimization, and the production of reliable actions. This regime is incompatible with the ease regime associated with joy.

Imagine a desk containing a computer and a pencil. Each object recruits a large network of learned causal relationships, action tendencies, and predictions. A pencil is typically assigned less value than a computer and is therefore treated as more easily replaceable. It is grasped in a particular way, used while monitoring spelling, returned to its usual location, and often checked afterward to ensure it has not been misplaced.

These rules are also linked to object categorization. A pencil is perceived as "just a pencil," whereas a computer is regarded as valuable because of its many functions. Each object therefore automatically recruits its customary meaning together with the actions normally associated with it.

As learning accumulates, behavior becomes increasingly organized around local optimization. Each selected action automatically recruits the next preferred action policy.

The **M-ZRT** introduces brief discontinuities into these chains before they become fully stabilized (Appendix 1).

Why the M-ZRT Targets Optimization

Some exercises briefly perturb object categories, others interrupt familiar action sequences, while others deliberately leave a sequence incomplete. Together, these micro-perturbations are hypothesized to reduce the rigidity of the underlying action structure, thereby increasing the probability that the ease regime will emerge.

Each M-ZRT exercise is effective only if the brain treats it as a minor, inconsequential perturbation. This is the central challenge of the method. It is also difficult because it runs counter to the principles of flow, a deeply ingrained mode of operation. For this reason, the task is psychologically counterintuitive.

If the exercises are approached too seriously, the brain naturally reinstates comparison, evaluation, prediction, and monitoring. According to the theory, this reactivates the control regime that competes with the ease regime. From that point onward, the task no longer increases the probability of entering a state compatible with joy, it may even reduce it.

To illustrate this principle, consider the exercise **"Modify Your Path."**

Under ordinary circumstances, a player in an RPG walks directly toward their destination. In this exercise, they introduce a slight deviation for no particular purpose. For example, they may change direction for a second or casually walk around an insignificant object before returning to their original route.

The primary activity remains moving through the game world. The alteration of the path is the perturbation.

Beginners often find this exercise surprisingly difficult because it interrupts an action sequence that is already underway. Interestingly, many people find it easier to complete a complex task than to introduce a small arbitrary perturbation into an ongoing action. For some, solving a puzzle or meditating requires less effort than walking in a slightly different direction for two seconds.

With practice, however, more advanced exercises gradually become easier as well.

Conclusion

Once these exercises are understood and performed naturally, they may already have been sufficient to produce a brief episode of joy, or even to open the ease regime.

They can be applied across a wide variety of contexts, and some target the mechanisms of action more directly and more strongly than others.

The broader objective is to maintain the ease regime even in evaluative environments, a problem that the present theoretical framework naturally seeks to address.

References:

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Appendix 1 Exercises That Can Be Performed at a Desk

These exercises are provided for informational purposes. Remember that trying to optimize the task goes against its very principle. The principal cause of failure is doing too many of them.

- For a brief moment, treat a completely ordinary object as highly important. Chair → Highly important.
- For a brief moment, hold an object that is about to be thrown away as if it were a treasure, then place it in the trash without hesitation. Trash → Treasure → Trash.
- For a brief moment, treat two different objects as having the same value Chair ≈ Lamp.
- For a brief moment, treat two options as equally acceptable. Option A ≈ Option B
- After looking at the time, briefly imagine that a different time appears instead. For example, **11:24 → 7:13** or **11:24 → 14:31**
- Check the time once. Do not immediately look again to confirm it. Continue normally. 11:24 → Seen once .
- Look at the time without immediately judging whether it is early, late, good, bad, useful, or problematic. For a brief moment: 11:24 → Seen before evaluated
- After seeing the time, allow a brief curiosity such as "Already?" or "Really?" to appear. For a brief moment: 11:24 → "Already?"
- Briefly look at one visual detail that is currently irrelevant. Door → Wood grain
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Object Categories

- Briefly observe an object as if no particular action were associated with it. Chair -> seen.
- Observe an object as though its function had not yet been decided. Chair → Function undecided.
- Look at an ordinary object and briefly experience it as not entirely matching its usual category. Chair → Not quite a chair
- Look at an object and allow two different associations to become possible at the same time. For example, chair → "satellite" and "animal." Do not choose between them.
- Looking at something, an internal description starts but remains unfinished. Example: *"This is a…"*.
- Notice that several explanations about a characteristic of an object could be generated. Select none of them. Explanation A → Possible.Explanation B → Possible. Explanation C → Possible

Thoughts

- Experience the feeling of being about to mentally say something, without needing the sentence itself. Leave the sentence unborn. Thought → About to be said
- A sentence begins internally and then loses momentum before reaching its end. Nothing needs to replace it. For a brief moment: *"Maybe the reason is..."*
- A prediction starts forming and remains incomplete. For a brief moment: *"If I open this menu, I'll probably..."* interrupting the formation of an anticipated future.
- A sentence begins and several endings briefly seem available. None are chosen. For a brief moment: *"Maybe the reason is..."*
- Something feels as though it could be interpreted or understood further. The interpretation does not occur. Object → Could be understood further
- Briefly suspends the expectation that the next thought must already be known. Current thought → ?
- A feeling of curiosity appears. Nothing is done to satisfy it immediately. For a brief moment: *"I wonder what's in there."* *"I wonder why that happened."*